BUILDING THE YOUNG INDIA

Education and employment for youth were and will be the ministry's main focus alongside unleashing their sporting spirit

By Kaushik Deka



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THE YOUTH, OR THOSE AGED between 18 and 29, number 261 million, or 22 per cent of India's population—larger than the population of Pakistan. The ministry of youth affairs and sports has a crucial role in guiding this demographic dividend to the country's advantage. The ministry has prepared a new draft National Youth Policy (NYP), an upgrade of the 2014 edition. The draft envisages a 10-year vision for youth development. Aligned with the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) adopted by the United Nations, it seeks to "unlock the potential of the youth to advance India" by catalysing action across five priority areas—education, employment & entrepreneurship, youth leadership & development, health, fitness & sports, and social justice.

Sports is an integral part of any policy aimed at supporting the youth. Currently, the Department of Sports runs the following schemes to promote sports in India: Khelo India, assistance to national sports federations, special awards to winners in international events and their coaches, national sports awards, pension to meritorious sportspersons, Pt. Deendayal Upadhyay National Welfare Fund for Sportspersons, National Sports Development Fund and sports training centres through the Sports Authority of India. In the past three years, Rs 6,601 crore was allocated to these schemes. ■

WORK DONE

- More than 125 youths participated in foreign exchange programmes in the past year
- 472,160 youths participated in 5,902 neighbourhood youth parliament programmes in 2021–22
- 247 sports academies accredited under Khelo India
- 100 new sports infrastructure created or upgraded last year
- 2,000 sportspersons provided scholarships last year
- 370 athletes assisted at home and abroad under National Sports Development Fund

CHALLENGES AHEAD

- Clean up malpractices in various sports federations
- Recently, the SC constituted a three-member Committee of Administrators (CoA) to run the day-to-day affairs of the All India Football Federation because of the illegal continuation the president despite expiry of the term
- Free federations from clutches of politicians
- Fast-track preparations for the 2024 Paris Olympics